



Apt finish: The climax to the Formula 1 World Championship could hardly have been better set up, with the three title contenders lined up together at the front of the grid for the Abu Dhabi Grand Prix. GETTY IMAGES

allowed drivers to race freely without team orders.

Norris, however, bounced back, clinching three of the next four races, including a surreal home Grand Prix at Silverstone. It was another lifelong goal accomplished, but the ultimate prize looked out of reach.

At Zandvoort, he approached the weekend full of promise, but a sudden reliability issue forced him to retire, extinguishing the momentum he had built. He sat alone on the grassy banks of the orange-clad track, watching in dismay as the gap to Piastri stretched to its widest point.

Fault lines

It was becoming clear that the competition between the teammates would not settle easily. McLaren held firm to its principle of healthy racing for as long as it could, an earnest attempt to keep two evenly matched contenders in harmony. But by the Italian Grand Prix, that balance gave way.

A botched pit stop for Norris forced McLaren to assert itself: Piastri was instructed to cede second place, stunning him and everyone watching. The team had declared its

number one driver, and it was not the championship leader.

The decision struck a nerve with Piastri. Sudden insecurity and a perceived lack of support sent his form into decline. He never voiced disapproval, but the youngster's dejection was unmistakable. His freefall began with a crash at the next race in Azerbaijan, where Norris, despite the chance to strike, could not fully capitalise.

Amid the shifting tides, the hegemony atop the leaderboard that the two teammates once held comfortably began to feel precarious. An unlikely contender surged back, winning three of the four races from Italy, and in doing so, Verstappen roared back into contention.

Cli'Max

Following the Dutch Grand Prix, Verstappen was a distant third in the standings, 104 points behind Piastri. It had been a strangely subdued campaign for a driver who had left the field gasping in previous seasons, with only two wins from the first 15 races.

Some traits, though, have always defined the Dutchman: he is never

far from the fight, and pressure often brings out his best. With renewed pace in the Red Bull and the poise of a four-time world champion, he emerged as a threat with nothing to lose.

At the US Grand Prix, Verstappen claimed maximum points from the sprint and main race. His surge was no longer a faint prospect but a gathering inevitability. This purple patch coincided with Piastri's final day in the lead and marked the juncture at which Norris' momentum started to shift.

The South American leg of the season saw Norris rediscover his long-lost mojo, excelling in Mexico and Brazil to reclaim the top spot. Piastri's penalty in Sao Paulo widened the gulf, while Verstappen's pit lane-to-podium masterclass brought him closer to the two.

Against the shimmering backdrop of Las Vegas, all the frontrunner needed was a win to seal his place, but nothing came easy. He lost prime position to Verstappen, and McLaren suffered its biggest debacle of the season: a double disqualification for breaching a technical regulation. It stripped Norris of second and Piastri of